
We Have a New Worst Star Wars Movie

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The good news about *The Mandalorian and Grogu* is you don't have to have seen all three seasons of the streaming TV show to enjoy the story of a ruthless bounty hunter and his little green sidekick. The bad news is I don't know what you'd have to do to have a good time at this lifeless, half-hearted movie, which brings *Star Wars* back to movie theaters for the first time in seven years, since the similarly dreadful [The Rise of Skywalker](#). Take an edible? Guzzle cough medicine? Or just set your expectations so low you could trip over them? Perhaps a nice pre-film lobotomy would do the trick.

When it arrived in 2019, [The Mandalorian](#) felt like a blessed reprieve from the lore-encrusted bent of [Rogue One](#) and [Solo](#), small-minded stories crammed into the gaps in the original trilogy like wads of paper beneath a wobbly table. The stories were largely self-contained adventures, with the occasional deep-cut reference for hardcore fans, but you didn't need to know a Jawa from a Tauntaun to follow along. This didn't last, of course: The mysterious mercenary acquired a name (if not often a face) and Baby Yoda got one, too, as the story grew more complicated and consequential—or so I gather, because when the first season ended with a revelation that was [only intelligible to viewers versed in the animated series The Clone Wars](#), I was out. It seemed as if the show and its creator, Jon Favreau, had glimpsed a way to a brighter future, one that looked back to [the series' inspiration in featherweight Flash Gordon serials](#), and purposefully turned away, or had his hand forced by a studio that was mostly concerned with compelling fans to keep consuming and unwilling to run the risk of having a satisfying ending.

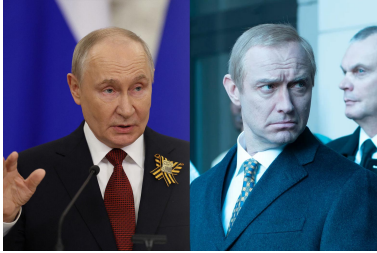
The movie, directed by Favreau, who also co-wrote the screenplay with Dave Filoni and Noah Kloor, represents yet another fresh start. Though it brings back a handful of characters, including the warlord Janu (Jonny Coyne) from *The Mandalorian* Season 3, and Jabba the Hutt's twin cousins from [The Book of Boba Fett](#), knowing that isn't necessary to follow along. (If you know the *Mandalorian* and Grogu, you can follow *The Mandalorian and Grogu*.) But though the movie doesn't get ensnared in past story, it neglects to come up with one of its own. There's the outline of a plot, in which Mando (voiced by Pedro Pascal, but played largely by a helmeted Brendan Wayne and Lateef Crowder) is sent to hunt down a foe of the New Republic and winds up being hunted himself. But it never develops beyond a rough sketch, lazily meandering through two hours and change as if the mere presence of familiar characters is enough to keep the audience from drifting away.

If *The Mandalorian and Grogu* isn't the worst *Star Wars* movie—and it might be—it's certainly the least: the least essential, the least engaging, the least necessary. Say what you want about [The Phantom Menace](#), but George Lucas had something he wanted to get off his chest. (Also, the pod-racing scene is pretty neat.) From its opening sequence, Favreau's movie displays a near-total lack of urgency, which might be fine if we were simply in hangout mode. The movie's environments, from a neon-lit netherworld to a remote jungle fortress, are rich and detailed, with the lived-in quality that distinguished Lucas' world from so many other sci-fi sagas. But the characters in them are stiff and shapeless, their dialogue flat and functional.

It's the latter that proves the movie's most genuinely shocking lapse. Lucas' dialogue could be strained and unnatural—as Harrison Ford once told him, "[You can type this shit, but you can't say it](#)"—but it at least strove for a sense of occasion. Favreau, Filoni, and Kloor's script doesn't even try to sing. As part of their initial mission, which involves trading favors with the Hutt twins in order to secure information vital to the New Republic, Mando and Grogu visit a down-and-dirty planet where Jabba the Hutt's son, Rotta (voiced by Jeremy Allen White), has been pressed into service as a

gladiator, fighting creatures in the arena until he has paid off his debts. (If you're wondering how a giant slug can fight, this one has—and I wish I were making this up—bulging biceps and six-pack abs.) Mando offers to free him, but Rotta declines, because he's also hoping that his victories will help him make a name for himself. He laments, "Do you know how hard it is to be your own man when your dad is Jabba the Hutt?" It certainly doesn't help that this movie's Hutts inexplicably speak perfect English, a jarring departure from Jabba's rumbling Huttese, or that White's vocal performance is somehow both affectless and unrecognizable. But the problem is with the line itself, a terrible clunker that only leaves you wondering what "being your own man" means to a character who isn't a man to begin with.

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It's not surprising, then, that the best parts of *The Mandalorian* and *Grogu* are those in which there's almost no talking at all. Although he's little more than a cuddly sidekick for most of the movie's first hour, Grogu gets to take center stage when Mando is sidelined, and the sequences from his point of view—which is to say, that of a curious, occasionally willful child who also has quasi-magical powers—are a true, if far too brief, delight. (There are, technically, a few words spoken in these segments, but since the semi-comprehensible utterances belong to a trio of adorable mini aliens voiced by Shirley Henderson, [Babu Frik herself](#), it's a bit of a gray area.) Baby Yoda may be a puppet, but he's still more expressive than a man in a helmet (or even, frankly, than Pascal, for the one scene in which we get a glimpse of his face). It's like seeing a now-familiar world through a fresh pair of eyes, and for a few minutes, you remember why this fictional universe has endured for so long, drawing in generation after generation. But then Mando takes charge again, and you're back in our universe, where they just keep throwing *Star Wars* at the wall, and nothing seems to stick.

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